A Trace of Panic

By David Cale

INTRODUCTION

Every person is special in some way and different from every other person on earth. Even the personalities of identical twins are different because they are affected by influences that impact on their lives in different ways. Personality development has been a major topic of interest for some of the most prominent thinkers in psychology. Our personalities make us unique, but how does personality develop? How exactly do we become who we are today? A Trace of Panic by David Cale is an absurdist piece about a man who co-ops bits and pieces of other people's personalities in an attempt to develop one of his own. A Trace of Panic by David Cale.

A MAN WITHOUT A NAME, *he speaks in a voice that* is *a cross between William Burroughs and the narration to a forties film noir. Nothing* is *his own.*

My mother's name was Paranoia. My father's name was Panic. They lived in a place where gray was the color of choice. On a windy day the preacher of the town decreed,

"I name these neuroses man and wife."

When I was born my mother's best friend, Chemical Dependency, looked at me and cried, "Oh, Paranoia, you must be so happy, he looks just like you, but there's definitely a trace of Panic in his eyes. And he's already wailing about something, and I bet he doesn't know what it is he's wailing about. That's a good sign. He'll fit right in 'round here."

My parents forgot to give me a name, so I was always referred to as Paranoia's son, or the child of Panic.

And childhood for me was one long walk down a lonely lane.

As Paranoia got older she grew clouds around her head. Till eventually all she could see were the clouds. So she started growing eyes all over her body. At a certain

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point the eyes started looking inward. Paranoia watched her every move all the time, and she became like a truck whose alarms would go off every time she got into her own driving seat. As she got older she stopped moving at all, she just stood in one place with all her eyes blinking, her alarms ready to go off, and the clouds drifting slowly around the features on her face. Nothing got better for Paranoia. From the day she was born it was all downhill.

Which was just the way she thought it would be. Panic spent most of his time standing on the fence smoking cigarettes, running away from views and muttering, "I can't deal with this. I don't want to know."

One day they both just disappeared. The theory was, they'd canceled each other out. All I inherited was the prison they lived in.

Well, one day I slipped through my own bars and made my getaway.

I was always drawn to the sky, so I spent most of my youth gazing out of windows.

"You were a bird in a former life," a fortuneteller told me.

"What about this time around?" I cried.

"I don't see anything for you but your past. Your past stretches all the way into where the future should be." ("Some accent, Madame Fong!")

"There must be some mistake," I cried.

"The cards don't lie," she said.

"Can we play another round?" I inquired. "Give me a chance to win back what I lost."

I started drifting. Anyplace I'd hang my hat was home. I moved in with a little woman called Safety Net. Safety was drawn to blank sheets like me. She got pleasure from coloring people in.

Safety had photographs of her parents all over her house. On one alarming day I noticed she had cut up and glued a photo of her face over the top of her

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mother's face, and a photo of my face was stuck on top of her father's. Instinct told me it was time to be moving along.

But Safety's photo collage had planted an idea in me. You see, Panic and Paranoia had neglected to give me any kind of character, so I decided to use myself as a canvas and snip away the pieces of other people's personalities that I was drawn to and stick them to me.

I soon became a well-balanced mixed platter, suitable for parties or office functions, or just something to nibble on. I wasn't a real meal, but I was happy. And Panic and Paranoia seemed like something I'd made up. Something that had never happened to me.

Though occasionally I'd look up at the sky and wonder if they were my mother's clouds.

Then I made a big mistake. The relationship with Safety was strictly platonic. You see at this point I had no sexuality. Everyone said that I should adopt one from the pound. There were all these unwanted sexualities desperately looking for a home. So that's where I went.

Dima Dozen ran the pound. A recovering dominatrix, Dima was an expert in drawing the line. She gave me the tour.

"If the sexualities are here for more than forty-eight hours, they're put to sleep. All our sexualities are de-flead. They've all had their shots. Oh, and choose carefully, all sexualities are nonreturnable."

Initially I couldn't see anything I was drawn to. Then I noticed a big, dark thing with needy eyes, separated from the rest.

"What's this one, Dima?" I inquired.

"Oh, that sexuality has no name."

I thought of myself, also drifting without a name, and a strange kind of bonding took place. At which point the sexuality jumped up and licked me on the

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face, and the look in its eyes told me the poor thing had been alone as long as I had.

"This is the one for me, Dima."

"Are you sure you can manage?" she asked. "This sexuality is very strong. Untrained. It'll need a substantial leash. And remember, it has to go everywhere with you."

"Dima, I'm alone in life. I've got nothing better to do than look after a big, uncontrollable sexuality," I naively replied.

I called my sexuality Scruffy. Scruffy and I left the pound with a sense of optimism. At last we'd both found constant companions. But reality was 'round the corner waiting to pounce on me and change all that.

I'd wake up every morning and Scruffy would be in my face. It would get hyper. Walking the streets it wanted to jump up on everyone. People backed away from me 'cause it was clear I wasn't walking the sexuality, but the sexuality was walking me. Dima's words echoed in my ears:

"All sexualities are nonreturnable, returnable, returnable .... "

Then I woke up one morning and looked down and there were little eyes growing all over me, and a subtle-looking cloud was passing my left eye. Mother! I had wondered where Paranoia had gone all those years, she was hiding out inside me. And I knew deep down, something was aggravating Scruffy. It was Panic. There was no choice but to visit Init Forthemoney. Dr. Forthemoney was an ex-mercenary and onetime bounty hunter who now had a thriving Freudian practice. She had the word "Passive" tattooed on one knuckle and the word "Aggressive" tattooed on the other. She'd clench the two and make a strange growling noise. *Grrrr!*

"What does your mother look like, so I know what to look for?" she inquired. *"Grrr!"*

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"Picture a cumulus cloud with bad shoes, Doc."

"And your father?"

"The Santa Ana winds with a cigarette."

A couple of days later she gave me her initial report.

"Inside you looks like bad weather. Take off your clothes, I need to look at your mother's eyes."

I obliged. There was something strangely calming about standing naked in front of such a total professional.

Scruffy, don't even consider it!

"What's all this?" the Doc asked. "You have all these bits of personality attached to you. This isn't your sense of humor. These aren't your opinions. That laugh isn't you. And they have little labels with dates on them."

"That's when I got them, Doc."

"They're coming off!"

"Ow!"

She yanked at the pieces of personality. "Ow, but I'm used to them now."

"This isn't you!"

"Ow!"

"And this here, is this you?"

"No, Doc. Ow!"

"I can't get to your mother and father without my assistant Seda Tive." Suddenly the door flung open. *[Wolf whistle]*

"Shut up, Scruffy!"

Seda Tive was a slinky little tablet with the vocal cords of a dove. She was wearing a dress made out of clear water. **It** was love at first sight. Seda threw her arms around me.

"Take me," she cooed. "I'll get rid of Paranoia. I'll get rid of Panic. Take me."

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How could I say no.

"Oh, Seda," I uttered, "I'm feeling better already. What did you do with mother and father?"

"I'm not telling," she cooed, "take me again."

"Oh, you beautiful relaxant, you, **I'm** starting to find you irresistible" were the last words I remember uttering.

When I came to I was wrapped in bandages, lying in the hospital. Dr. Forthemoney had removed Mother's eyes. They were glaring at me from the inside of a jar. I looked out the window and I noticed the sky had a few extra clouds. And Father was blowing around outside. The operation had been a success. I looked to my left and Seda Tive had gone, and she'd taken Scruffy with her. *Such is life,* I thought to myself, wiser but no more bitter.

Leaving the sanitarium, as we all must do, eventually, I waved at the elements that once were my parents. The sky that day seemed particularly blue.

Naw I'm a clean slate, I thought to myself, *a blank page. A new chapter. Just waiting to be written.*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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